

“Mere protestations of *Mera Bharat Mahan*, without addressing the basic fissures, will not save India.”

LEAD FACTOR

He lived for his beliefs and did not mind dying for them. His uncommon courage was critical in standing up to the state and preserving the democratic fabric of Independent India.

Jayaprakash Narayan

Political activist 1902-1979

■ By Raghuvansh Prasad Singh

Times come and go, with people leaving their footprints on history. But Jayaprakash Narayan's life was a history of his times. He had such an impact on people that I still remember him vividly after all these years. He was the greatest orator I have ever seen. Wherever he went, there would be thousands of people waiting to listen to him. Yet that was only one side of him. The other was of a quiet man who would devour books on Marxism, and for whom freedom was to later become a call for *sampoorna kranti*.

JP, as he was popularly known, was a product of the varied experiences he had in life. He was born in Lalatoli, a small village in Bihar, and his father worked in the state's irrigation department. From small town Bihar, it was a whole world of discovery when he went to the US for higher studies. While in college, he worked in a packaging company to finance his studies. That is where his tryst with Marxism began, through books written by M.N Roy. On his return, he met Mahatma Gandhi who became his mentor. He was part of the Congress for a long time but later felt his ideology was completely different. It was then that JP, along with his friends Yusuf Desai and Ram Manohar Lohia, formed the Congress

